

September

21



1937

The Hobbit

British fantasy writer J R R Tolkien's novel *The Hobbit* was published. It introduced readers to Middle Earth and Bilbo Baggins's quest for treasure guarded by the dragon Smaug.

Born this day

1979 Chris Gayle, West Indian cricketer. He was the first to score centuries in all three forms of the game.

1898 Empress Dowager

Chinese emperor Guangxu's adoptive mother, the Empress Dowager Cixi, opposed his Hundred Days of Reform, which sought to modernize China. She imprisoned him and took charge of the Qing Dynasty.



1912 Incredible stunt

Hungarian-American illusionist Harry Houdini first performed his Chinese Water Torture Cell stunt in Berlin, Germany. To the astonishment of those watching, he escaped a water tank after being lowered into it upside down with his feet locked.

Also on this day

1522 The New Testament of the Bible was translated from Latin into German by German reformer Martin Luther, making it more accessible.

1792 The French legislative assembly voted to abolish the monarchy one year after most of King Louis XVI's powers had been taken away.

2018 Japan became the first country to land robots on an asteroid. These tiny rovers took pictures to send back to Earth.